

## The Digital World

A Round-up Of Technology News From Across The Globe

### UNITED STATES

It has recently been reported that high-tech companies are going overseas to find talent not being produced in the US. More than half of the computer scientists in the US are foreign-born. From Google's Sergey Brin (Russia) to Yahoo's Jerry Yang (Taiwan), immigrants are rising to the top of US-based high-tech industries.

### FINLAND

Digital signatures via SIM cards and mobile phones have taken off in Finland. The Finnish Population Register Centre now offers its citizens the option of conducting official business over the Internet. This allows the citizen to use a mobile telephone when secure identification is required for online services or requests.



### CHINA

South Korea's Samsung has announced it plans to make China its second R&D base and its global R&D centre. At a conference on R&D strategy in China, which ended August 16, Lee Yoon-woo, vice chairman of Samsung Electronics, said China was of strategic importance.



### UAE

On August 8, Samsung announced plans to kick off the Olympics of the cyber-gaming community, the 'World Cyber Games 2005', in the UAE. The first cyber-gaming championship, too, took place in the UAE. This year again, Samsung will host the UAE round in alliance with its local partner eCompany's online gaming service engine [www.mplayer-arabia.com](http://www.mplayer-arabia.com).

### MALAYSIA

The number of broadband users is growing by 30,000 new users per month. At that rate, it is expected that Malaysia will have 700,000 broadband users by the middle of 2006. Malaysia's population is about 24 million.



### AUSTRALIA

Australia said on August 17 it was developing battlefield robots capable of military operations that could free soldiers from some dangerous tasks. The new systems will be intelligent and largely autonomous.

material's 'fingerprint'. The system then records the naturally-occurring pattern of imperfections. These are impossible to replicate as they are very minute in nature.

This technology could be used on materials such as passports, ID cards, credit cards, CDs and DVDs, banknotes, and packaging.

The scientists involved in the project said this system offers a much simpler, largely foolproof, and inbuilt—thus cheaper—way to authenticate and track sensitive documents than current methods such as holographs.

The 'fingerprints' of the materials are made up of variations of ridges and grooves, which characterise materials. These imperfections are of the order of a few hundred nanometers.

Scientists at Imperial College and Durham University used an optical phenomenon known as 'laser speckle' to detect the variations in surfaces. Laser speckle occurs when a focused beam of laser light scatters over a random

system, such as a paper surface. The scanner records the way the laser light is reflected off the surface of the paper or plastic.

The speckles, as with human fingerprints, are almost unique. The researchers working on the system said it could help to clamp down on fraud, drug counterfeiting, terrorism and identity theft.

### EVEN CHEAPER CELL PHONES?

## New Platform To Lower Handset Costs

Infineon Technologies has announced sample availability of its first reference design for ultra-low-cost handsets. Using their new ULC reference platform based on a single-chip GSM solution, costs for GSM handsets with SMS functionality could be reduced by nearly half in the near future.



## Three Incredibly Useful Sites

Info, scams, and news insights

### www.infoplease.com



### infoplease

Here's "all the knowledge you need", as the homepage says. You need to take a look at this site to believe the sheer amount and range of information available. Quizzes, polls, crosswords, culture, almanacs, atlases, history, an encyclopaedia, a dictionary, a thesaurus...

### www.scambusters.org



### ScamBusters.org

"ScamBusters Helps You Protect Yourself From Clever Scams—Online and Offline," and there are a variety of resources and links on this page to that end. Even if you don't think you are or will be a victim of fraud, the site is fun to navigate—it has links such as 'Urban Legends', 'Scam Check', 'Viruses', 'Credit Card Fraud', and so on.

### www.storydata.com



### STORYDATA.COM

The homepage says the site helps you get "more insight out of the stories that affect our world." When we last checked, featured stories included 'fiscal implications of ageing,' 'patterns of global terrorism,' 'the costs of a bioterrorist attack,' and many more. The stories here seem genuinely insightful, and all the sources of information seem authentic.